Installing JS8FastChat on Linux

Version 1.76 · everything here runs on the Linux PC, in a terminal

Download the .tar.gz from github.com/mjordan501/JS8MapChat/releases into Downloads, open a terminal with Ctrl+Alt+T, paste the block of commands and press Enter. Paste the whole block at once.

1 Before you start

- **Download the _Linux.tar.gz from GitHub.** It is on the Releases page of github.com/mjordan501/JS8MapChat; your browser saves it in Downloads. Do not unpack it yourself; the commands do that.
- **Install JS8Map Spotter first** and let its first-run setup download the callsign databases. FastChat reads them, and the buttons between the two programs need JS8Map.
- **Have your password ready.** The installer may need to add python3-tk (Python 3.8 or newer with Tk), and recommends unzip, wmctrl and xdotool. Linux Mint is where it is tested most.

2 Install JS8FastChat

The file: `JS8FastChat_Ver_1.76_build_2026-10-31_Linux.tar.gz`, from the Releases page.

On the Linux PC, in a terminal:

```
F="$(ls -t ~/Downloads/JS8FastChat_Ver_*_Linux.tar.gz | head -n 1)"
mkdir -p ~/Applications && tar -xzf "$F" -C ~/Applications
sh ~/Applications/"$(tar -tzf "$F" | head -n 1 | cut -d/ -f1)"/linux_install.sh
```

Easiest: copy these lines from the JS8FastChat README on GitHub; its command boxes have a copy button.

It unpacks the newest JS8FastChat download in Downloads into `~/Applications` and sets it up there.

Its questions end in [y/N]: type y and press Enter for yes. Enter alone means no.

It asks	Answer
Install command: sudo apt install … Run it now? [y/N]	Type y, press Enter, then type your password. Adds python3-tk if it is missing, plus unzip, wmctrl and xdotool. Only asked if something is missing.
An older JS8FastChat is installed in ~/.local/lib/JS8FastChat … Remove the old copy? [y/N]	Type y. That is version 1.75.1 or earlier; your settings are not in it. Only asked if it is there.
An older copy is in: … Remove it? (your settings are kept) [y/N]	Type y to tidy up an earlier version left in ~/Applications. Only asked if one is there.

When it says DONE, a JS8FastChat icon is in the menu (Ham Radio / Internet) and on the desktop. The installer does not start the program: set up JS8Call first (next section), then click the icon.

3 Set up JS8Call

In JS8Call: File > Settings > Reporting. Tick Enable TCP Server API and Accept TCP Requests, port `2442`, TCP Max Connections `5`. Restart JS8Call.

Each program that talks to JS8Call takes one connection: JS8Map, JS8FastChat, and any companion such as JS8Spotter or CommStat. At the default of 1 there are not enough to go round, and the program left out fails silently.

Start order: JS8Call, then JS8Map, then JS8FastChat.

4 Update to a newer version

Close JS8FastChat, download the new _Linux.tar.gz from the Releases page into Downloads, and paste the same block again. It installs the new version in `~/Applications`, offers to remove the older copy, and moves the menu entry and desktop icon to the new one. Your settings are kept.

5 Where everything is

What	Where
The program	`~/Applications/JS8FastChat Ver 1.76`
Settings and logs	`~/.local/share/JS8MapChat/FastChat`
JS8Map handoff	`~/.local/share/JS8MapChat/Shared` (used by JS8Map too)
Menu entry and desktop icon	`~/.local/share/applications/js8fastchat.desktop` and JS8FastChat on the desktop
The download	`~/Downloads/JS8FastChat_Ver_1.76_…_Linux.tar.gz` — only the package; delete it after installing

Settings are never in the program folder, so installing, updating or removing the program never touches them.

6 Remove JS8FastChat

Close JS8FastChat first. On the Linux PC, in a terminal:

```
rm -rf ~/Applications/"JS8FastChat Ver "*
rm -f ~/.local/share/applications/js8fastchat.desktop
rm -f ~/Desktop/JS8FastChat.desktop
```

Easiest: copy these lines from the JS8FastChat README on GitHub; its command boxes have a copy button.

The three lines remove the program, its menu entry and its desktop icon; each one works on its own. Your settings stay in `~/.local/share/JS8MapChat/FastChat`; delete that folder too if you want them gone. Leave the Shared folder beside it alone: JS8Map uses it.

7 If something goes wrong

You see	It means
ls: cannot access … No such file	The .tar.gz is not in Downloads. Check the download finished, then paste the block again.
STOP: still missing: python3-tk	The packages were skipped. Paste the block again and type y at Run it now?, or run `sudo apt install python3-tk`.
Stations show, but the frequency and offset boxes stay empty and nothing sends	JS8Call refused FastChat's connection. Set TCP Max Connections to 5 (section 3) and restart JS8Call.
Desktop icon says Untrusted	Right-click it and choose Allow Launching (Mint: double-click > Mark as Trusted).
The JS8Map Spotter button does nothing	Run `sudo apt install wmctrl xdotool`. On a Wayland desktop, log out and pick the Xorg / X11 session on the login screen.